BEHAVIORAL INTERVIEW PREPARATION SYSTEM

For Software Engineering Internships and Early-Career Roles

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What this document is. A working system for turning your real engineering experience — the Financial Account Aggregation API, LedgerCore, the FarmLink hackathon, Robotics Club, and the KNUST CS Open Source Community — into a small set of stories you know so well that you can answer almost any behavioral question naturally, without a memorized script.

What this document is not. It is not a list of answers to memorize. There are no paragraphs written for you to recite. Every story card has blanks marked **[FILL IN]** where only you can supply the real detail — the exact number, the exact moment, the exact words someone said. If you fill in a blank with something that didn't happen, the system breaks the first time an interviewer asks a follow-up.

IMPORTANT: This document never invents an event, a metric, a conflict, or a failure on your behalf. Where your background material didn't include a specific detail (an exact number, a specific conflict, a specific piece of feedback), you'll see a bracketed prompt instead of a fabricated answer. Filling those in honestly, before your interview, is part of the preparation — not an optional extra.

How to use this document

- Read Parts 1–2 once, so you understand what behavioral interviews are actually measuring.
- Spend most of your time in Part 3 and Part 5 — build your Story Bank and fill in every [FILL IN] blank with a real, specific, honest detail.
- Use Part 6, Part 8, and Part 24 for practice — out loud, not silently in your head.
- Use Part 20 (rubric) to score yourself honestly after each practice session.
- Review Part 26 (the Handbook) the night before an interview — not the whole document.

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PART 1

What Behavioral Interviews Actually Test

Why companies ask behavioral questions at all

A technical interview tells a company whether you can solve a defined problem in a defined amount of time. It does not tell them how you behave when a problem is ambiguous, when a teammate disagrees with you, when you're told your first idea is wrong, or when something you built breaks in a way you didn't anticipate. Almost all of real engineering work happens in exactly those conditions. Behavioral interviews exist to sample that part of the job.

The core assumption behind the format

The format rests on one assumption: **the way you handled a real situation in the past is the best available evidence for how you'll handle a similar situation in the future.** Not a perfect predictor — just the best evidence an hour-long conversation can produce. That's why interviewers keep steering you back to specifics ('what did *you* do', 'what happened next', 'why that option and not the other one') instead of accepting general statements about your personality or philosophy.

Why junior candidates are evaluated differently from senior engineers

An interviewer does not expect an intern or new-grad candidate to have led a team through a production outage or negotiated a cross-org technical decision. What they're actually checking for at your level is much more foundational:

- Can you accurately describe what you personally did, versus what a team or a tool did for you?
- Do you notice when something goes wrong, or do you only notice when someone else points it out?
- When you're shown you're wrong, do you get defensive, go quiet, or actually update your approach?
- Can you explain a technical decision to someone who doesn't share your technical context?
- Do you already have the instinct to check your own work, rather than assuming it's right?

This is good news: it means your academic projects, your hackathon, and your club leadership are not a weaker substitute for "real" experience — for an internship-level interview, they *are* the real evidence the interviewer is looking for.

Why technical ability alone is not enough

Software is built by teams, reviewed by other engineers, and eventually explained to people who did not write it — product managers, support teams, other engineers six months later, sometimes regulators or customers. An engineer who can write correct code but can't explain a tradeoff, can't say "I was wrong about this," or can't work through a disagreement, is expensive to work with regardless of how good the code is. Behavioral interviews are the company's attempt to price that cost in before they hire you, not after.

Why interviewers ask follow-up questions

A rehearsed answer and a lived experience sound identical for about 30 seconds. They diverge the moment someone asks a question you didn't prepare for — "why didn't you just do X instead," "how did you know it actually worked," "what would you do differently now." Interviewers drill down specifically *because* a first answer is cheap to prepare. Your job is not to have a perfect first answer; it's to know your own experience deeply enough that the fifth follow-up question is no harder to answer than the first.

The underlying competencies repeat, even when the wording doesn't

"Tell me about a challenge," "tell me about a time something didn't go as planned," and "tell me about a difficult problem you solved" are, underneath the wording, often the same question. This document is built around that idea: instead of memorizing answers to hundreds of possible phrasings, you learn roughly 24 underlying competencies (Part 2) and a small set of real stories (Part 3) that map onto them (Part 4), so that any new phrasing is just a matter of picking the right story and adjusting emphasis — not writing a new answer from scratch.

PART 2

Behavioral Competency Map

24 competencies interviewers actually screen for. For each: what it means, what strong and weak evidence look like, which of your stories can carry it, and where the gaps are.

Communication

What it means: Explaining ideas so the listener actually understands, adjusting to their background, and listening as much as you talk.

What the interviewer is checking: Can this person be understood by teammates, PMs, and non-engineers?

Strong evidence: Clear structure, checks the listener understood, adapts language to audience, answers the question asked.

Weak evidence: Jargon-heavy, rambling, monologuing, never checks in.

Your candidate stories: S3, S8, S9

Common questions: Explain a technical concept to a non-technical person; describe your role on a project.

Common mistake: Explaining a system the way you'd explain it to another engineer, regardless of who's asking.

Teamwork

What it means: Working productively inside a group toward a shared goal.

What the interviewer is checking: Do you make the people around you more effective, or do you work in spite of them?

Strong evidence: Names specific teammates' contributions, describes real coordination, shows shared credit without erasing personal contribution.

Weak evidence: Only 'we', no visible personal role, or the opposite: no one else in the story at all.

Your candidate stories: S6, S7, S8

Common questions: Tell me about working on a team; a time you helped a teammate.

Common mistake: Using 'we' so consistently the interviewer can't find you in your own story.

Conflict resolution

What it means: Handling a disagreement without damaging the relationship or avoiding the issue.

What the interviewer is checking: Do you address disagreement directly and respectfully, or avoid/escalate it?

Strong evidence: States both perspectives fairly, focuses on evidence/reasoning, reaches or works toward a resolution.

Weak evidence: Makes the other person look foolish, avoids the conflict entirely, or claims there was never any disagreement.

Your candidate stories: S11 (template — fill in)

Common questions: Disagreement with a teammate; a difficult teammate.

Common mistake: Framing the other person as simply wrong instead of holding a different, reasonable view.

Leadership

What it means: Taking responsibility for outcomes beyond your own individual task, often by enabling other people.

What the interviewer is checking: Do you step up, and do you make others better, or just yourself?

Strong evidence: Concrete actions that changed what other people did (taught, organized, unblocked), with a result.

Weak evidence: A title with no described action ('I was Training Lead') or credit-taking for others' independent work.

Your candidate stories: S6, S7

Common questions: A time you demonstrated leadership; a time you influenced a team without authority.

Common mistake: Reciting a title instead of describing an action.

Ownership

What it means: Treating a problem as yours to solve even when it isn't strictly your assigned responsibility, and being accountable for the outcome.

What the interviewer is checking: When something in your area breaks, do you own it or point elsewhere?

Strong evidence: "I noticed / I decided / I was responsible for", follows through past the comfortable stopping point.

Weak evidence: Vague responsibility, or credit for success without acknowledging responsibility for the parts that went wrong.

Your candidate stories: S1, S2, S4

Common questions: A time you took ownership; a time something in your project broke.

Common mistake: Taking ownership of successes only.

Initiative

What it means: Starting something valuable without being told to.

What the interviewer is checking: Do you wait for instructions, or do you notice gaps and act?

Strong evidence: Names the gap you noticed and the unprompted action you took.

Weak evidence: Initiative claimed for something that was actually assigned.

Your candidate stories: S8, S9

Common questions: A time you took initiative; a time you went beyond what was asked.

Common mistake: Describing an assigned task as if it were self-initiated.

Problem solving

What it means: Working systematically from a symptom to a root cause and a working fix.

What the interviewer is checking: Is your process organized, or do you get lucky / guess-and-check?

Strong evidence: Names hypotheses considered and how each was tested; explains why the final approach won.

Weak evidence: "I looked at it and eventually found the bug" with no visible reasoning.

Your candidate stories: S1, S3, S4

Common questions: A difficult technical problem; a bug you had to track down.

Common mistake: Skipping straight to the fix without showing the diagnostic reasoning.

Failure and learning

What it means: Recognizing a genuine mistake, owning it, and changing behavior afterward.

What the interviewer is checking: Do you have real self-awareness, or only manufactured humility?

Strong evidence: A real mistake with real consequences, followed by a concrete, lasting behavior change.

Weak evidence: A 'fake failure' (a humblebrag) or a real failure with no described change afterward.

Your candidate stories: S10 (template — fill in)

Common questions: Tell me about a failure / mistake.

Common mistake: Choosing a failure that is actually a strength in disguise ('I worked too hard').

Coachability

What it means: Actually changing your behavior in response to feedback, not just agreeing with it politely.

What the interviewer is checking: Will this person improve after we invest in mentoring them?

Strong evidence: Specific feedback received, specific behavior changed, evidence the change stuck.

Weak evidence: "I'm very open to feedback" with no example of feedback ever changing what you did.

Your candidate stories: S12 (template — fill in)

Common questions: A time you received difficult feedback.

Common mistake: Describing being told something without describing anything you did differently after.

Adaptability

What it means: Adjusting your plan, approach, or expectations when circumstances change.

What the interviewer is checking: Do you rigidly stick to the original plan even after it stops working?

Strong evidence: Names what changed, what you adjusted, and why the adjustment was reasonable.

Weak evidence: A plan that never needed to change (not a real adaptability story).

Your candidate stories: S3, S6

Common questions: A time you had to adapt; a time requirements changed.

Common mistake: Choosing a story where nothing was actually forced to change.

Prioritization

What it means: Deciding what matters most when you can't do everything at once.

What the interviewer is checking: Do you have a reasoning process for tradeoff decisions under time pressure?

Strong evidence: Names the competing items, the criteria used, and the choice made and why.

Weak evidence: "I just did everything" (avoids the actual prioritization question).

Your candidate stories: S6, S9

Common questions: Competing priorities; limited time or resources.

Common mistake: Not admitting that something was deliberately deprioritized.

Working under pressure

What it means: Maintaining judgment and output quality when time, stakes, or visibility increase.

What the interviewer is checking: Do you degrade gracefully or panic/freeze under pressure?

Strong evidence: Describes the pressure concretely (deadline, stakes) and how you managed focus, not just the outcome.

Weak evidence: Pressure claimed but not actually present in the story (e.g., a relaxed weekend project).

Your candidate stories: S6

Common questions: A high-pressure situation; a tight deadline.

Common mistake: Overstating pressure that wasn't really there, which falls apart under follow-up.

Handling ambiguity

What it means: Making forward progress when requirements, scope, or the right approach are unclear.

What the interviewer is checking: Do you stall waiting for clarity, or do you make reasonable assumptions and move?

Strong evidence: Names the specific ambiguity and how you resolved or worked around it.

Weak evidence: A story where everything was actually already well-specified.

Your candidate stories: S5, S8

Common questions: A time requirements were unclear; a time you had to figure things out yourself.

Common mistake: Confusing 'hard' with 'ambiguous' — they're not the same thing.

Decision-making

What it means: Choosing between real alternatives using explicit reasoning.

What the interviewer is checking: Is there an actual decision process, or did you just do the first thing that occurred to you?

Strong evidence: States the alternatives seriously considered, the deciding factor, and the result.

Weak evidence: A 'decision' where there was really only ever one option.

Your candidate stories: S1, S5

Common questions: A difficult decision; a time you chose between two approaches.

Common mistake: Presenting the option you didn't pick as obviously bad, in hindsight, to make your choice look better than it was at the time.

Technical communication

What it means: Describing a technical system or decision at the right level of depth for the listener.

What the interviewer is checking: Can you scale explanation depth up and down on request?

Strong evidence: A layered explanation: one-sentence version first, more detail available on request.

Weak evidence: One fixed level of detail regardless of who's asking or how they react.

Your candidate stories: S3, S5

Common questions: Explain a project; explain a technical decision.

Common mistake: Front-loading implementation detail before establishing why the system exists.

Explaining complex concepts simply

What it means: Translating jargon into plain, accurate language without dumbing it down incorrectly.

What the interviewer is checking: Could a non-engineer stakeholder follow this?

Strong evidence: Uses an analogy or plain restatement that stays technically accurate.

Weak evidence: Simplifying to the point of being misleading, or not simplifying at all.

Your candidate stories: S3, S5

Common questions: Explain something technical to a non-technical audience.

Common mistake: Reaching for an analogy that breaks down under a follow-up question.

Persuasion

What it means: Getting someone to seriously consider or adopt your position using reasoning and evidence.

What the interviewer is checking: Do you convince with evidence, or push, or give up too early?

Strong evidence: Names the other party's initial position, the evidence/argument you used, and what changed.

Weak evidence: "I convinced them" with no description of how.

Your candidate stories: S8

Common questions: A time you persuaded someone; a time you changed someone's mind.

Common mistake: Persuasion stories that are actually just 'I was right and they eventually agreed' with no real description of the exchange.

Dealing with disagreement

What it means: Staying constructive when someone (a peer, a tool, an AI suggestion) pushes back on your view.

What the interviewer is checking: Composure and reasoning under pushback.

Strong evidence: Calm, evidence-based response; willing to update if the pushback has merit.

Weak evidence: Digging in regardless of evidence, or caving regardless of evidence.

Your candidate stories: S2, S11 (template)

Common questions: Disagreement with a suggestion, a reviewer, or a teammate.

Common mistake: Treating every disagreement as something you must 'win'.

Time management

What it means: Getting real output delivered within a deadline.

What the interviewer is checking: Do you plan realistically and adjust, or discover the deadline too late?

Strong evidence: Names how you sequenced or scoped work to hit a real deadline.

Weak evidence: No visible planning, just an outcome.

Your candidate stories: S6, S9

Common questions: A tight deadline; a hackathon.

Common mistake: Skipping straight to the result without the planning that got you there.

Accountability

What it means: Accepting the consequences of your own actions, including unflattering ones, without deflecting.

What the interviewer is checking: When it's your fault, do you say so?

Strong evidence: Explicit "that was on me" language followed by a fix.

Weak evidence: Passive voice that hides who was responsible ('mistakes were made').

Your candidate stories: S10 (template)

Common questions: A time you made a mistake.

Common mistake: Technically admitting fault while emotionally blaming circumstances or other people.

Attention to quality

What it means: Catching problems before they become someone else's problem — correctness, edge cases, data integrity.

What the interviewer is checking: Do you check your own work, or rely entirely on others (reviewers, tests, AI) to catch issues?

Strong evidence: A specific edge case, duplicate, or race condition you caught and why you looked for it.

Weak evidence: "I always write clean code" with no concrete example.

Your candidate stories: S1, S2, S4

Common questions: A time you caught a bug before it shipped; a quality/correctness story.

Common mistake: Confusing 'quality' with 'style' rather than correctness and reliability.

Responsible use of AI

What it means: Using AI tools to move faster while still owning correctness, security, and understanding of the result.

What the interviewer is checking: Are you leveraging AI, or outsourcing your judgment to it?

Strong evidence: A concrete moment you verified, tested, or rejected an AI suggestion.

Weak evidence: Either denying using AI at all, or describing it as a black box you trust without checking.

Your candidate stories: S2

Common questions: How do you use AI when coding? Tell me about a time you disagreed with an AI suggestion.

Common mistake: Overclaiming AI fluency, or being unable to say how you verify AI output.

Customer / user focus

What it means: Making decisions based on what the eventual user of the system actually needs, not just what's technically interesting.

What the interviewer is checking: Do you think about who's affected downstream?

Strong evidence: Explains a decision in terms of the effect on the end user or data integrity for real accounts.

Weak evidence: Purely internal/technical framing with no mention of who the system serves.

Your candidate stories: S3, S4

Common questions: A time you made a decision with the user in mind.

Common mistake: This is a genuine moderate-strength area for a student project — be honest that your 'users' were often simulated (mock bank providers) rather than real customers, and say so if asked directly.

Curiosity

What it means: Going a level deeper than required because you wanted to actually understand something, not just make it pass.

What the interviewer is checking: Will this person grow, or plateau at 'good enough'?

Strong evidence: A specific instance of digging past the first working answer.

Weak evidence: "I love learning" with no concrete instance.

Your candidate stories: S1, S2, S9

Common questions: A time you went deeper than necessary; a time you taught yourself something.

Common mistake: Confusing curiosity with general enthusiasm about the field.

Career motivation

What it means: Having a coherent, honest reason for pursuing this field and this type of role.

What the interviewer is checking: Is this genuine interest, or a generic answer that would fit any candidate?

Strong evidence: Specific, personal, tied to real projects and what you want to learn next.

Weak evidence: Generic ('I love solving problems and working with people').

Your candidate stories: See Part 7

Common questions: Why software engineering? Why this role? Where do you see yourself in 5 years?

Common mistake: An answer that would be equally true if you'd never written a line of code.

PART 3

Your Story Bank

9 stories anchored in your real projects, plus 3 explicitly-marked gap templates for competencies your background material didn't document a story for.

These are not 12 unrelated anecdotes. They're chosen so that, together, they cover almost every competency in Part 2 (see the coverage matrix in Part 4). You do not need more stories than this — you need to know these few in enough depth to bend them to whatever's actually asked.

IMPORTANT: Three of the twelve rows below (S10, S11, S12) are templates, not finished stories. Your source material documented real projects and technical themes (concurrency, provider failures, duplicate prevention, AI-assisted development) but did not include a specific interpersonal conflict, a specific piece of critical feedback you received, or a specific failure with known consequences. Rather than invent one, this document leaves those three as structured blanks. Part 25 explains why that gap exists and how to close it honestly before your interviews.

Story	Task	Actions	Result	Lesson	Competencies
S1 LedgerCore — Concurrency & Idempotency	Ensure double-entry transfers stayed consistent under concurrent access.	Diagnosed a consistency risk in concurrent transfers; reasoned about transaction isolation, idempotency keys, and retry logic; validated with concurrent stress tests.	[FILL IN: outcome of stress tests — did they pass, what changed]	Correctness under concurrency has to be tested under concurrency, not assumed from code review.	Problem solving, ownership, quality, technical communication, decision-making
S2 LedgerCore — Rejecting an AI Suggestion	Use AI to accelerate development on LedgerCore while remaining responsible for correctness.	An AI-suggested change would have masked an underlying data problem rather than fixing it; recognized this, rejected the suggestion, and pursued the actual root cause instead.	[FILL IN: what the AI suggested specifically, and what the real root cause turned out to be]	AI output has to be evaluated against understanding of the system, not accepted because it compiles or looks plausible.	Responsible AI use, quality, technical judgment, ownership, curiosity
S3 Aggregation API — Provider Failures & Rate Limiting	Keep account linking and sync working when a mock bank provider fails or rate-limits requests.	Designed handling for provider failure and rate-limit scenarios; considered retry/backoff and failure-isolation tradeoffs so one failing provider wouldn't degrade the whole system.	[FILL IN: how the system behaved under simulated provider failure — recovery time, failure isolation]	Design for the failure case, not just the happy path, especially in a system that touches financial data.	Problem solving, tradeoffs, resilience/adaptability, technical communication
S4 Aggregation API — Duplicate Prevention in Background Sync	Prevent duplicate transactions during background transaction synchronization.	Identified how duplicates could enter the system during sync/retries; implemented a deduplication approach; verified it held up across repeated sync runs.	[FILL IN: how duplicates were confirmed fixed — test result, before/after]	Idempotent processing is not automatic in a distributed/background system — it has to be deliberately designed in.	Attention to quality, problem solving, ownership, debugging

Story	Task	Actions	Result	Lesson	Competencies
S5 Aggregation API — Kafka/Redis Architecture Tradeoff	Choose an approach for background processing and caching of account/transaction data.	Evaluated using Kafka for background /event-driven processing and Redis for caching/rate-limit state against simpler in-process alternatives; chose based on the system's actual needs.	[FILL IN: the simpler alternative you considered and the specific reason you didn't pick it]	Infrastructure choices should be justified by real requirements (throughput, decoupling, resilience), not by what's trendy.	Decision-making, tradeoffs, technical communication, handling ambiguity
S6 FarmLink — Youth Arise Hackathon (Team Nova, won)	Build a working product under hackathon time constraints as part of Team Nova.	[FILL IN: your specific role and actions — what you personally built, decided, or presented]	Team Nova won the hackathon. [FILL IN: what you'd credit the win to, and any real metric — team size, timeframe, judging criteria]	[FILL IN: your main takeaway from the experience]	Teamwork, pressure, prioritization, time management, presenting, adaptability
S7 Robotics Club — Training Lead & Programmer	Train and support other members as Training Lead while also contributing as a programmer.	[FILL IN: specific things you did to train/mentor others — a curriculum, a session, a specific member you helped]	[FILL IN: an observable result — a member's improvement, a competition result, a project shipped]	[FILL IN: what you learned about teaching or leading]	Leadership, mentoring, communication, teamwork, initiative
S8 KNUST CS Open Source Community — Pitch Coaching	Work with a 3-person team to build and pitch projects, and help other teams refine startup ideas.	[FILL IN: a specific team and idea you helped refine, and specifically what you contributed — feedback, restructuring the pitch, technical framing]	[FILL IN: what happened to that idea/pitch afterward, if known]	[FILL IN: what you learned about persuasion or technical communication]	Persuasion, communication, collaboration, initiative
S9 Learning Fast — New Technology for the Aggregation API	Get productive with unfamiliar tools (e.g., Kafka, Redis, async processing patterns) fast enough to use them correctly in the system.	[FILL IN: which specific technology was newest to you, and how you actually learned it — docs, a small prototype, trial and error]	[FILL IN: evidence you actually understood it — a decision you could defend, a bug you could diagnose]	[FILL IN: what you'd do differently next time you need to ramp up fast]	Curiosity, learning agility, initiative, technical communication
S10 TEMPLATE — A Genuine Failure or Mistake	[FILL IN: what you were responsible for]	[FILL IN: what specifically went wrong, and how you found out]	[FILL IN: what you did once you knew, and what actually happened afterward]	[FILL IN: what you changed about how you work as a result]	Failure and learning, accountability, ownership, coachability
S11 TEMPLATE — A Real Disagreement With a Person	[FILL IN: the shared goal you and the other person both had]	[FILL IN: what you each believed and why]	[FILL IN: how the disagreement actually got resolved, or didn't]	[FILL IN: what you learned about handling disagreement]	Conflict resolution, communication, dealing with disagreement, emotional maturity

Story	Task	Actions	Result	Lesson	Competencies
S12 TEMPLATE — Feedback You Received and Acted On	[FILL IN: who gave the feedback and in what context]	[FILL IN: the feedback itself, as close to their actual words as possible]	[FILL IN: the specific thing you did differently afterward]	[FILL IN: evidence the change actually stuck or helped]	Coachability, self-awareness, adaptability

PART 4

Story Coverage Matrix

You don't need 50 stories. These 12 rows, used flexibly, cover nearly every competency.

Read the matrix by competency (column), not just by story (row): if a question targets 'Leadership', scan down that column for a filled cell, then pick whichever story best fits the specific wording of the question. A cell marked with a dash means that story isn't a natural fit for that competency — don't force it.

Story	Lead	Conf	Fail	Tech	Team	Lrn	Pres	Own	AI
S1 LedgerCore Concurrency	-	-	-	H	-	M	-	H	-
S2 Rejecting AI Suggestion	-	L	-	H	-	M	-	H	H
S3 Provider Failures	-	-	-	H	L	M	M	M	-
S4 Duplicate Prevention	-	-	L	H	-	M	-	H	-
S5 Kafka/Redis Tradeoff	-	-	-	H	L	M	-	M	-
S6 FarmLink Hackathon	M	-	-	M	H	M	H	M	-
S7 Robotics Training Lead	H	-	-	M	H	M	-	M	-
S8 KNUST CS Pitch Coaching	M	L	-	L	H	M	-	L	-
S9 Learning Fast	-	-	-	M	-	H	M	L	-
S10 Failure (template)	-	-	H	?	-	H	-	H	-
S11 Disagreement (template)	-	H	-	?	M	M	-	-	-
S12 Feedback (template)	-	-	-	-	-	H	-	-	-

Columns: **Lead**=Leadership, **Conf**=Conflict, **Fail**=Failure, **Tech**=Technical, **Team**=Teamwork, **Lrn**=Learning, **Pres**=Pressure, **Own**=Ownership, **AI**=AI Judgment

H = strong fit **M** = moderate/secondary fit **L** = light/possible fit **-** = not a natural fit **?** = depends entirely on which real incident you fill in.

PART 5

The Story Card System

Full working cards for all 12 stories. Practice talking through these points out loud, in your own words, in a different order each time. Never read one aloud verbatim — that's the one thing that turns a real story into a script.

S1 — LedgerCore — Concurrent Transfer Consistency

One-sentence version: I found and closed a consistency risk in how LedgerCore handled simultaneous transfers, and proved the fix with concurrent load tests rather than just code review.

BLUF (say this first)

The core risk was that two concurrent transfer requests touching the same account could interleave in a way that broke double-entry consistency; I addressed it with transaction isolation, idempotency keys, and retry logic, then validated it under real concurrent load.

Situation (only the context needed)

LedgerCore is a FastAPI + PostgreSQL double-entry ledger and settlement system. Double-entry means every transfer has to debit one account and credit another as a single atomic fact — if that ever gets out of sync, the ledger is no longer trustworthy.

Task (my responsibility)

My responsibility was to make sure the transfer path stayed correct when multiple transfers hit the same account at the same time, not just when tested one request at a time.

Actions (what I personally did)

- Reasoned through what could go wrong when two requests for the same account overlapped — specifically around transaction isolation level and double-processing on retries.
- Implemented idempotency keys so a retried request couldn't be applied twice.
- Used database-level transaction isolation and locking so concurrent writes to the same account couldn't interleave incorrectly.
- Added retry logic for the cases where a transaction had to legitimately be retried after a conflict, rather than assuming the first attempt always succeeds.
- [FILL IN: any specific bug or near-miss you found while doing this — a real detail makes this concrete under follow-up questions]
- Built and ran concurrent stress tests specifically designed to hit the same accounts from multiple simultaneous transfers, rather than relying on single-request tests.

Result

[FILL IN: what the stress tests actually showed — did they catch a real issue, confirm the fix held, at what concurrency level did you test]

Metrics

> [FILL IN: real numbers if you have them — number of concurrent transfers tested, pass rate, any latency numbers. If you don't have exact numbers, say 'No verified metric available' rather than estimating.]

What I learned

Code that looks correct reading it top to bottom can still be wrong under concurrency — the only way to be confident is to actually generate concurrent load and watch what happens, not just reason about it.

What I'd do differently

[FILL IN: e.g., would you design the stress tests earlier, log more state during testing, or something else specific]

Competencies demonstrated

Problem solving, Ownership, Attention to quality, Technical communication, Decision-making, Curiosity

Technical depth available if asked

Can discuss: PostgreSQL transaction isolation levels, why double-entry accounting requires atomicity, idempotency key design, retry-after-conflict logic, how the stress test was structured.

Likely follow-up questions

- Why idempotency keys specifically, instead of just relying on database locks?
- What transaction isolation level did you use, and why that one instead of a stricter or looser one?
- How did you generate concurrent load for the stress test?
- What would happen if two retries of the same request arrived out of order?
- How did you know the fix actually worked, versus just not seeing a failure in your test run?
- What's the worst case if this bug had shipped to production?
- Did you consider using a queue to serialize writes per account instead?
- How long did it take you to find this, and what made you look for it in the first place?

S2 — LedgerCore — Rejecting an AI Suggestion That Would Have Masked a Bug

One-sentence version: An AI coding assistant suggested a change that would have made a symptom disappear without fixing the underlying data problem, and I rejected it in favor of finding the actual root cause.

BLUF (say this first)

The AI's suggestion would have suppressed an error rather than fixing what caused it, which in a ledger system would have let bad data pass silently; I traced the real cause instead and fixed that.

Situation (only the context needed)

> I was using an AI coding assistant to speed up development on LedgerCore. At one point it proposed a fix for an issue I was working through.

Task (my responsibility)

My responsibility was to make sure whatever went into LedgerCore was actually correct, not just quiet — especially since this is a financial ledger where a silently-swallowed error can mean data that looks fine but isn't.

Actions (what I personally did)

- [FILL IN: what the AI actually suggested — e.g., catching/suppressing an exception, adding a default value, skipping a check]
- Recognized that the suggestion would remove the symptom (an error or failure) without addressing why the error was happening in the first place.
- Rejected the suggestion rather than accepting it because it was fast or because it made the immediate problem go away.
- [FILL IN: how you actually traced the real root cause — what you looked at, what you found]
- Implemented a fix that addressed the actual cause instead of the symptom.
- [FILL IN: how you verified the real fix, e.g., tests, manual verification]

Result

> [FILL IN: what the real root cause turned out to be, and what changed once it was fixed properly]

Metrics

No verified metric available unless you have a specific before/after data point (e.g., a specific class of bad records that stopped appearing).

What I learned

AI-assisted development speeds up writing code, but it doesn't understand the system's actual invariants (in this case, what 'correct' means for a ledger) — that judgment still has to come from me.

What I'd do differently

[FILL IN, optional]

Competencies demonstrated

Responsible use of AI, Attention to quality, Ownership, Technical judgment, Curiosity, Decision-making

Technical depth available if asked

Can discuss: what the AI suggested, why it would have masked rather than fixed the issue, how you found the real cause, and generally how you validate AI-generated suggestions in a system where correctness matters (financial/ledger data).

Likely follow-up questions

- What exactly did the AI suggest?
- How did you know it was masking the problem rather than actually fixing it?
- What was the real root cause?
- How long did it take you to find the real fix compared to just accepting the AI's answer?
- Do you usually accept AI suggestions, or do you check all of them this closely?
- How do you decide when to trust an AI suggestion versus dig deeper?
- Has an AI tool ever given you a suggestion that you accepted and later regretted?
- What's your general process for reviewing AI-generated code before it goes in?

S3 — Aggregation API — Provider Failures and Rate Limiting

One-sentence version: I designed how the account aggregation system handled a bank provider being down or rate-limiting requests, so one failing provider wouldn't take down account syncing for everyone.

BLUF (say this first)

The main risk was that a single mock bank provider failing or rate-limiting could cascade into failures across the whole sync pipeline; I designed retry/backoff and failure isolation so one provider's problems stayed contained.

Situation (only the context needed)

The Financial Account Aggregation API (built with FastAPI, PostgreSQL, Redis, and Kafka) links user accounts to mock bank providers and keeps transaction data in sync with them. Providers can fail or rate-limit requests, which is realistic behavior for real bank integrations.

Task (my responsibility)

My responsibility was the account linking and transaction synchronization logic, including how it behaved when a provider wasn't cooperating.

Actions (what I personally did)

- Identified the specific failure modes to design for: a provider being fully down versus a provider rate-limiting requests — these need different handling.
- Used retry with backoff for transient failures instead of failing the whole sync immediately.
- Used Redis to track rate-limit state so the system could back off from a specific provider without needing to hit it again just to find out it was still limiting requests.

- Designed the failure handling so one provider's issues were isolated and didn't block syncing for accounts on other providers.
- [FILL IN: how you tested this — did you simulate provider failure/rate-limiting against the mock providers, and what did you observe]

Result

[FILL IN: concrete outcome — e.g., sync for unaffected accounts continued normally during a simulated provider outage, or a specific recovery behavior you observed]

Metrics

> [FILL IN if available: retry counts, backoff intervals used, or number of providers/accounts in your test setup. Otherwise: No verified metric available.]

What I learned

In a system that talks to external providers, failure handling isn't a nice-to-have — it has to be part of the initial design, because provider failure is a normal, expected condition, not an edge case.

What I'd do differently

[FILL IN, e.g., would you add circuit-breaking, more granular per-provider metrics, etc.]

Competencies demonstrated

Problem solving, Tradeoffs, Adaptability, Technical communication, Attention to quality

Technical depth available if asked

Can discuss: retry/backoff strategy, why Redis for rate-limit state, failure isolation between providers, how this interacts with background sync via Kafka.

Likely follow-up questions

- What's the difference in how you handled a total outage versus a rate limit?
- Why Redis for tracking rate-limit state instead of just an in-memory counter?
- How did you test provider failure without a real bank to fail?
- What happens to a transaction sync that was in progress when a provider started failing?
- How would this scale if you had 50 providers instead of a few mock ones?
- What would you add if you had another two weeks on this?
- How do you decide how long to back off before retrying?
- What's the tradeoff between retrying aggressively and giving up too early?

S4 — Aggregation API — Preventing Duplicate Transactions in Background Sync

One-sentence version: I closed a path where background transaction synchronization could record the same transaction twice, by deliberately designing for duplicate prevention rather than assuming sync would only ever run once per transaction.

BLUF (say this first)

Background sync jobs can retry or overlap, and without explicit dedup logic that risks double-recording transactions; I designed the sync path so repeated or overlapping runs couldn't create duplicates.

Situation (only the context needed)

The Aggregation API synchronizes transaction data from linked bank accounts in the background, which means sync jobs can be retried (e.g., after a provider or network hiccup) or can potentially overlap.

Task (my responsibility)

My responsibility was making sure that a transaction that had already been recorded wouldn't get recorded again just because the job that fetched it ran more than once.

Actions (what I personally did)

- Identified the specific ways a duplicate could enter the system: retried sync jobs, provider responses being replayed, or overlapping sync windows.
- Designed a deduplication approach based on stable transaction identifiers rather than relying on sync-run timing to avoid overlap.
- [FILL IN: the specific mechanism — e.g., a uniqueness constraint at the database level, a dedup check before insert, or both]
- Tested by deliberately re-running sync against the same data to confirm it didn't create duplicate records.

Result

[FILL IN: what you observed when you tested repeated sync runs — did duplicates stop appearing, how did you confirm]

Metrics

> [FILL IN if available: number of duplicate records before the fix versus after, or number of repeated-sync test runs performed. Otherwise: No verified metric available.]

What I learned

'Exactly-once' processing doesn't happen by accident in a background/distributed system — it requires an explicit identifier and check, because retries and overlaps are a normal part of how these systems behave.

What I'd do differently

[FILL IN, optional]

Competencies demonstrated

Attention to quality, Problem solving, Ownership, Debugging

Technical depth available if asked

Can discuss: what made a transaction identifier stable enough to dedup on, where the dedup check lived (application layer vs. database constraint), how this interacts with retries from the provider-failure handling in S3.

Likely follow-up questions

- What made a transaction's identifier reliable enough to dedup on?
- Did you enforce this at the database level, the application level, or both, and why?
- How did you first notice duplicates were even possible?
- What would happen if the provider itself sent the same transaction with two different IDs?
- How does this interact with the retry logic from provider failures?
- How did you test this without waiting for a real duplicate to occur naturally?
- What's the performance cost of the dedup check, if any?
- Is this a bug you found, or a risk you designed against before it happened?

S5 — Aggregation API — Kafka/Redis Architecture Tradeoff

One-sentence version: I evaluated using Kafka for background/event-driven processing and Redis for caching and rate-limit state against simpler alternatives, and chose based on what the system actually needed rather than defaulting to the most popular tools.

BLUF (say this first)

The decision came down to whether background transaction processing needed to be decoupled and event-driven or could stay simpler and synchronous; given multiple providers and background sync requirements, I chose Kafka plus Redis over a simpler in-process approach.

Situation (only the context needed)

The Aggregation API needed to process account linking, transaction sync, and background jobs across multiple mock providers, with data normalization and rate-limit awareness in the mix.

Task (my responsibility)

Part of my responsibility was deciding how background processing and caching should be architected, not just implementing whatever was already decided.

Actions (what I personally did)

- Considered a simpler alternative: handling background work with, e.g., in-process background tasks or a simple job queue, without a message broker.
- Weighed that against Kafka, which decouples producers (things that trigger sync) from consumers (the workers doing the syncing) and handles backpressure and replay more naturally.
- Chose Kafka for background/event-driven processing because of the decoupling and resilience benefits given multiple providers and retryable failures (see S3/S4).
- Chose Redis specifically for caching and rate-limit/state tracking because it's fast for that kind of ephemeral, frequently-read state, not for durable storage.
- [FILL IN: any specific moment where the simpler alternative was seriously on the table and you had to justify the more complex choice]

Result

[FILL IN: how the architecture performed once built — did it hold up under your testing, did the decoupling actually pay off in a concrete way]

Metrics

> No verified metric available unless you have a specific comparison (e.g., a load test comparing the two approaches). It's fine to say so directly if asked.

What I learned

Choosing infrastructure should start from the failure modes and throughput needs you actually expect, not from which tool is most interesting to use — complexity has to earn its place.

What I'd do differently

[FILL IN, e.g., would you introduce Kafka this early again, or start simpler and add it later]

Competencies demonstrated

Decision-making, Tradeoffs, Technical communication, Handling ambiguity

Technical depth available if asked

Can discuss: what Kafka buys you over a simple queue (decoupling, replay, backpressure), why Redis rather than an in-process cache, how PostgreSQL fits as the system of record versus Kafka/Redis as processing/caching layers.

Likely follow-up questions

- What would you have lost by not using Kafka?
- At what point would the simpler alternative have actually been the better choice?
- How do Kafka and Redis divide responsibilities in your design?
- What's the failure mode if Redis goes down? What about Kafka?
- Was this your decision alone, or a team decision — what was your specific input?
- How would you explain this tradeoff to a non-technical stakeholder?
- What's the operational cost of running Kafka that a simpler approach wouldn't have?
- If you were rebuilding this today, would you make the same choice?

S6 — FarmLink — Youth Arise Hackathon (Team Nova, won)

One-sentence version: As part of Team Nova, I helped build FarmLink under hackathon time pressure, and the team won.

BLUF (say this first)

[FILL IN: your one-line summary of the biggest challenge and how the team/you solved it — e.g., 'The biggest challenge was X, and I solved it by Y']

Situation (only the context needed)

FarmLink was built as part of the Youth Arise hackathon, by Team Nova, under normal hackathon time constraints.

Task (my responsibility)

[FILL IN: your specific role on the team — e.g., which part of the product you owned, whether you focused on backend, frontend, pitching, or a mix]

Actions (what I personally did)

- [FILL IN: the specific technical or product work you personally did]
- [FILL IN: any decision you personally pushed for or made under time pressure]
- [FILL IN: how you coordinated with the rest of Team Nova — division of labor, how you kept the team on schedule]
- [FILL IN: how the team prepared and delivered the final presentation/pitch, and your part in it]

Result

Team Nova won the hackathon.

Metrics

[FILL IN: any real numbers — team size, number of teams competed against, hackathon duration, judging criteria if known. Otherwise: No verified metric available beyond the win itself.]

What I learned

[FILL IN: your real takeaway — e.g., about working under time pressure, about team coordination, about scoping ambition to time available]

What I'd do differently

[FILL IN, optional]

Competencies demonstrated

Teamwork, Time management, Working under pressure, Prioritization, Adaptability, Communication

Technical depth available if asked

[FILL IN: what tech stack FarmLink actually used, and one or two technical decisions you can defend in detail]

Likely follow-up questions

- What exact problem was FarmLink solving?
- What was your specific role versus the rest of Team Nova's?
- What did you personally build or decide?
- What did you have to cut or simplify because of the time limit?
- What was the biggest risk to finishing in time, and how did you manage it?
- How did the team divide the work?
- What made your submission win, in your view?
- What would you build next if you kept working on FarmLink after the hackathon?

S7 — Robotics Club — Training Lead and Programmer

One-sentence version: As Training Lead, I was responsible for helping other members build technical skill, while also contributing as a programmer on the club's own projects.

BLUF (say this first)

[FILL IN: e.g., 'The biggest challenge was getting new members from zero programming background to being able to contribute, and I solved it by...']

Situation (only the context needed)

I served as Training Lead and Programmer in the Robotics Club, meaning I had a dual role: developing other members' skills and doing hands-on programming work myself.

Task (my responsibility)

[FILL IN: the specific scope of the Training Lead responsibility — how many members, what skill level they started at, what they needed to learn]

Actions (what I personally did)

- [FILL IN: what training/teaching structure you actually built — sessions, a curriculum, pairing people up, hands-on exercises]
- [FILL IN: a specific member or group you helped and how]
- [FILL IN: how you balanced training responsibilities with your own programming contributions]
- [FILL IN: how you checked whether the training was actually working, rather than assuming it was]

Result

[FILL IN: an observable outcome — members who became able to contribute independently, a competition result, a project the club shipped]

Metrics

[FILL IN: number of members trained, timeframe, competition placement if any. Otherwise: No verified metric available.]

What I learned

[FILL IN: what you learned about teaching, mentoring, or leading that you didn't know before taking this role]

What I'd do differently

[FILL IN, optional]

Competencies demonstrated

Leadership, Mentoring, Communication, Teamwork, Initiative

Technical depth available if asked

[FILL IN: what technical material you were actually teaching — e.g., a programming language, robotics-specific concepts, hardware/software integration]

Likely follow-up questions

- How did you structure your training sessions?
- How did you handle members who were struggling to keep up?
- What was the hardest part of teaching something you already understood well yourself?
- How did you measure whether the training was effective?
- Tell me about a specific member you helped improve.
- How did you balance being 'Training Lead' with your own programming work?
- What would you change about how you ran training if you did it again?
- Did you ever get pushback or disagreement from a member about your approach?

S8 — KNUST CS Open Source Community — Pitch Coaching

One-sentence version: Working with a team of three, I helped build and pitch projects, and helped other teams refine their startup ideas and pursue outside opportunities.

BLUF (say this first)

[FILL IN: e.g., 'The biggest challenge was getting a team's pitch to actually explain the problem clearly, and I solved it by...']

Situation (only the context needed)

Within the KNUST CS Open Source Community, I worked as part of a 3-person team on our own projects, and separately helped other teams sharpen their startup ideas and pitches.

Task (my responsibility)

[FILL IN: your specific role — were you doing technical work, pitch coaching, or both; which team(s) you helped]

Actions (what I personally did)

- [FILL IN: a specific project you and your 3-person team built and pitched]
- [FILL IN: a specific instance of helping another team refine their idea — what was unclear about their original idea/pitch, and what you suggested]
- [FILL IN: how you communicated feedback to a team that wasn't yours — how you made sure it landed well]
- [FILL IN: any follow-through — did you help them pursue a specific external opportunity]

Result

[FILL IN: what happened to the idea/pitch after your involvement, if known]

Metrics

[FILL IN: number of teams helped, outcome of any external opportunity pursued. Otherwise: No verified metric available.]

What I learned

[FILL IN: what you learned about communication, persuasion, or technical framing from doing this repeatedly across different teams]

What I'd do differently

[FILL IN, optional]

Competencies demonstrated

Persuasion, Communication, Collaboration, Initiative

Technical depth available if asked

[FILL IN: what your own 3-person team actually built — stack and your role in it]

Likely follow-up questions

- What was the actual project your 3-person team built?
- What was your specific contribution versus your two teammates'?
- Tell me about one specific team you helped refine their pitch — what changed?
- How do you give feedback on someone else's idea without discouraging them?
- What made a pitch weak in the cases you saw, most often?
- Did any team push back on your feedback? How did you handle that?
- What outside opportunity did a team pursue, and what came of it?
- How is coaching someone else's idea different from pitching your own?

S9 — Learning Fast — New Technology for the Aggregation API

One-sentence version: I had to get productive quickly with technology that was new to me (e.g., Kafka, Redis, or async processing patterns) in order to build the Aggregation API correctly.

BLUF (say this first)

[FILL IN: e.g., 'The biggest challenge was understanding X well enough to make a real design decision, not just copy an example, and I solved it by...']

Situation (only the context needed)

Building the Financial Account Aggregation API required using technology I hadn't necessarily worked with in depth before — [FILL IN: name the specific one, e.g., Kafka, Redis, or async background processing patterns].

Task (my responsibility)

I needed to understand the tool well enough to make real design decisions with it (see S5), not just get a tutorial example running.

Actions (what I personally did)

- [FILL IN: how you actually learned it — official docs, a specific tutorial, reading source/examples, a small throwaway prototype before using it for real]
- [FILL IN: a specific concept that was initially confusing and how you worked through it]
- Validated understanding by using the tool to make an actual design decision (see S5) rather than just getting it to run.
- [FILL IN: how you checked your own understanding — e.g., could you explain why a particular configuration/pattern was needed, could you predict a failure mode]

Result

[FILL IN: evidence you actually understood it, not just used it — e.g., you could debug an issue with it, or justify a design choice using it]

Metrics

No verified metric available unless you have a specific timeframe (e.g., 'went from no experience with Kafka to using it correctly in the sync pipeline within [FILL IN timeframe]').

What I learned

[FILL IN: what your actual process is for learning a new technology fast — e.g., build something small and real before trusting yourself to use it in the main system]

What I'd do differently

[FILL IN, optional]

Competencies demonstrated

Curiosity, Learning agility, Initiative, Technical communication

Technical depth available if asked

[FILL IN: specific technical details about the technology you learned — enough to answer a follow-up question about how it actually works]

Likely follow-up questions

- What was the hardest part to understand at first?
- How did you know you understood it well enough to use it for real, not just copy an example?
- What resource or approach worked best for you when learning it?
- Did you make a mistake early on because you didn't fully understand it yet?
- How long did it take before you felt confident with it?
- How do you generally approach learning something you've never used before, under a deadline?
- What would you tell someone else on your team who had to learn this same thing?

- Is there a concept related to this tool you still don't fully understand?

S10 — TEMPLATE — A Genuine Failure or Mistake

One-sentence version: [FILL IN once completed]

BLUF (say this first)

[FILL IN: 'The mistake was X, it happened because Y, and here's what I changed.']

Situation (only the context needed)

[FILL IN: what you were working on and what your responsibility was at the time]

Task (my responsibility)

[FILL IN: specifically what you were supposed to deliver or ensure]

Actions (what I personally did)

- [FILL IN: what you actually did that turned out to be wrong, or what you failed to do]
- [FILL IN: how and when you found out it had gone wrong — did you catch it yourself or did someone else]
- [FILL IN: what you did once you knew — how you fixed or mitigated it]
- [FILL IN: who you told, and how you communicated the mistake]

Result

[FILL IN: the actual consequence, honestly stated — don't minimize it, and don't claim it 'all worked out perfectly' if it didn't]

Metrics

No verified metric available until you fill this in with a real incident.

What I learned

[FILL IN: the specific, lasting change to how you work as a result — not a vague 'I learned to be more careful']

What I'd do differently

[FILL IN: what you'd do differently if you were back at the start of that situation]

Competencies demonstrated

Failure and learning, Accountability, Ownership, Coachability

Technical depth available if asked

[FILL IN once you know which real incident this is]

Likely follow-up questions

- What exactly went wrong?
- How did you find out?
- Whose fault was it, in your honest assessment?
- What was the actual impact?
- What did you do in the first hour/day after realizing it?
- Has anything like this happened again since?
- What would you do differently if you saw the early warning signs again?
- How did the people around you react?

S11 — TEMPLATE — A Real Disagreement With Another Person

One-sentence version: [FILL IN once completed]

BLUF (say this first)

[FILL IN: 'We disagreed about X; I believed Y because Z, they believed otherwise, and here's how it resolved.']

Situation (only the context needed)

[FILL IN: the shared project or goal you and the other person were both working toward]

Task (my responsibility)

[FILL IN: what decision or approach was actually in dispute]

Actions (what I personally did)

- [FILL IN: what you believed and why, stated fairly]
- [FILL IN: what the other person believed and why — stated fairly, not as a strawman]
- [FILL IN: what you actually did to work through it — did you listen first, bring evidence, propose a compromise, escalate]
- [FILL IN: how it was actually resolved — who was right, or was it a compromise]

Result

[FILL IN: the actual outcome, and the state of the relationship afterward]

Metrics

No verified metric available until you fill this in with a real incident.

What I learned

[FILL IN: what you learned about handling disagreement specifically from this situation]

What I'd do differently

[FILL IN, optional]

Competencies demonstrated

Conflict resolution, Communication, Dealing with disagreement, Emotional maturity

Technical depth available if asked

[FILL IN once you know which real incident this is]

Likely follow-up questions

- What exactly did you disagree about?
- Did you consider that you might be wrong? What made you reconsider, if anything?
- How did the other person react to your pushback?
- Was this resolved, or did you just agree to disagree?
- How did this affect your working relationship afterward?
- Would you handle it the same way again?
- What would you have done if they outranked you or had more experience?
- What's the difference between healthy disagreement and just being difficult?

S12 — TEMPLATE — Feedback You Received and Acted On

One-sentence version: [FILL IN once completed]

BLUF (say this first)

[FILL IN: 'I was told X; at first I thought Y, but I changed Z, and here's what happened after.']

Situation (only the context needed)

[FILL IN: who gave you the feedback and in what context — a code review, a club leader, a hackathon teammate, a professor]

Task (my responsibility)

[FILL IN: what you were doing that the feedback was about]

Actions (what I personally did)

- [FILL IN: the feedback itself, as close to their actual words as you can recall]
- [FILL IN: your honest initial reaction — it's fine if it wasn't immediately positive]
- [FILL IN: what you specifically did differently afterward]
- [FILL IN: how you checked whether the change actually helped]

Result

[FILL IN: evidence the change stuck or made a real difference]

Metrics

No verified metric available until you fill this in with a real incident.

What I learned

[FILL IN: what this taught you about receiving feedback in general]

What I'd do differently

[FILL IN, optional]

Competencies demonstrated

Coachability, Self-awareness, Adaptability

Technical depth available if asked

[FILL IN once you know which real incident this is]

Likely follow-up questions

- What was your first reaction when you heard the feedback?
- Did you agree with it right away, or did it take time?
- What specifically did you change?
- How do you know the change actually helped, versus just feeling better about it?
- Has anyone given you similar feedback since?
- What kind of feedback is hardest for you to hear?
- How do you ask for feedback, rather than just waiting to receive it?
- Tell me about a time you disagreed with feedback you were given.

PART 6

Question → Story Mapping

For each canonical question: which story to reach for, why, what to actually say, and what follow-up to expect. This is a starting point, not a rule — if a question is phrased slightly differently, use Part 4's matrix to re-pick.

Question	Primary competency	Recommended story	Key points to hit	Expect this follow-up
Tell me about a time you failed.	Failure and learning	S10 (fill in first)	A real mistake, honestly owned, with a lasting behavior change afterward.	What would you do differently right now if you saw it happening again?
Tell me about a time you disagreed with someone.	Conflict resolution	S11 (fill in first) or S2 (disagreement with an AI suggestion)	Fair statement of both views; how it was resolved.	Did you ever consider you might be the one who was wrong?
Tell me about a time you received difficult feedback.	Coachability	S12 (fill in first)	The actual feedback, your honest first reaction, and what specifically changed after.	How do you know the change actually helped?
Tell me about a time you demonstrated leadership.	Leadership	S7 (Robotics) or S6 (FarmLink)	A concrete action that changed what other people did, not just a title.	What would you do if someone on the team ignored your guidance?
Tell me about a time you had to learn something quickly.	Curiosity / learning agility	S9	The specific technology, how you actually learned it, and how you validated your own understanding.	What's something related you still don't fully understand?
Tell me about a difficult technical problem.	Problem solving	S1 or S3 or S4	Lead with the BLUF: what the core risk was and how you closed it. Then the diagnostic process.	What alternatives did you consider before landing on this approach?
Tell me about a time you worked under pressure.	Working under pressure	S6 (FarmLink)	The real deadline/stakes, and how you kept quality up rather than just rushing.	What did you have to cut or simplify because of the pressure?
Tell me about a time you had competing priorities.	Prioritization	S6 or S9	Name the competing items explicitly and the criteria you used to choose.	What happened to the thing you deprioritized?
Tell me about a time you persuaded someone.	Persuasion	S8	The other person's starting position, your evidence/argument, and what actually changed.	What if they still hadn't agreed after that?
Tell me about a time you made a mistake.	Accountability	S10 (fill in first)	Explicit ownership language; don't let the sentence drift into passive voice.	What was the actual impact, in concrete terms?
Tell me about a time you disagreed with a teammate.	Conflict resolution	S11 (fill in first)	Same as 'disagreed with someone' — keep the other person's view fair and reasonable.	How is your relationship with them now?
Tell me about a time you had to explain something technical.	Technical co mmunication	S3 or S5	Start with the plain-language version; add technical depth only if they ask for it.	How would you explain the same thing to an engineer instead?

Question	Primary competency	Recommended story	Key points to hit	Expect this follow-up
Tell me about a time you took initiative.	Initiative	S8 or S9	The gap you noticed that nobody assigned you to fix, and the specific unprompted action.	Did anyone tell you not to, or was it outside your role?
Tell me about a time something did not go according to plan.	Adaptability	S3 or S6	What changed, what you adjusted, and why that adjustment was reasonable at the time.	How did you know your adjustment was the right one and not just a guess?
Tell me about a time you had to make a difficult decision.	Decision-making	S1 or S5	Real alternatives you seriously considered, not a strawman; the deciding factor.	What information did you wish you'd had before deciding?
Tell me about a time you received feedback.	Coachability	S12 (fill in first)	Feedback → reflection → behavior change → result, in that order.	What's feedback you've been given more than once?
Tell me about a time you helped someone else.	Teamwork / mentoring	S7	What the person couldn't do before, what you did, what they could do after.	How did you know they actually needed help, versus assuming?
Tell me about a time you had limited resources.	Prioritization / adaptability	S6	The specific constraint (time, people, tools) and how it shaped your approach.	What would you have built with no constraint at all?
Tell me about a time you had to adapt.	Adaptability	S3 or S6	Same guidance as 'didn't go according to plan' — needs a real forced change.	How long did it take you to realize the original plan wasn't working?
Tell me about a time you had to prioritize.	Prioritization	S6 or S9	Same guidance as 'competing priorities'.	Would you make the same call again?

PART 7

Deep Prep on the Highest-Stakes Questions

These get asked in almost every interview. Each section is a framework and a fill-in skeleton — not a script. Practice saying it differently each time.

1. Tell me about yourself

Target length: 60–90 seconds. Structure: who you are → what you're studying and building → what technical area genuinely interests you → what shaped that interest → what you're looking for next. Don't narrate your life story chronologically — pull out only the pieces that explain why you're in this interview.

- **Who I am:** [FILL IN: your name, program, year at KNUST]
- **What I build:** backend systems — e.g., "I've been building backend systems like a financial account aggregation API and a double-entry ledger system, working with FastAPI, PostgreSQL, Redis, and Kafka."
- **What draws me to that area:** [FILL IN: e.g., the part of backend engineering that genuinely interests you — correctness under concurrency, system design, data integrity]
- **What shaped that interest:** one concrete anchor — e.g., "working on LedgerCore is what got me interested in [FILL IN: specific sub-area]"
- **What I'm looking for:** [FILL IN: e.g., an internship where you can work on real systems with engineers more experienced than you, and get feedback that sharpens your judgment]

IMPORTANT: Do not build this around a childhood story or a fabricated 'always loved computers since I was 5' narrative unless it's literally true. A shorter, accurate answer beats a longer invented one.

2. Why software engineering / computer science?

Answer from your actual experience, not from a script about 'loving to solve problems.' What specifically do you enjoy: building something that works end-to-end, debugging something you don't understand yet until you do, seeing a system hold up under real conditions? Anchor it to one real moment — e.g., a specific point in LedgerCore or the Aggregation API where the work clicked for you.

> [FILL IN — your honest answer to: what's the actual moment or realization that made you want to do this, not the answer you think sounds best]

3. Why this company?

Never say 'your company is innovative and prestigious' — it's true of every company an interviewer has ever worked at, so it tells them nothing. Research four things and connect each to something genuine about you (see Part 17 for the full framework):

- What the company actually builds and who uses it.
- A specific technology or engineering challenge they're known for.
- What the specific team/role does day to day.
- What you'd genuinely learn there that you can't get from a class or a solo project.

Example structure (fill in real research per company, using Part 17): "[Company fact] is interesting to me because I've been working on [related thing from your projects], and I want to see how that works at a scale / with constraints I haven't dealt with yet."

4. Why this role?

Connect four things explicitly: your current skills + what you want to learn + what the role actually involves + why this is a good next step for your development. For an internship, it's fine — expected, even — to say you want mentorship and exposure to real systems, as long as you also show what you already bring.

5. Tell me about a project — at four depths

Use S1 (LedgerCore) or S3/S5 (Aggregation API). The core content doesn't change across lengths — only how much of it you say. Watch the interviewer: if they lean in or ask a follow-up before you finish, go deeper; if they're just nodding, wrap up.

30 seconds

> "LedgerCore is a double-entry ledger system I built with FastAPI and PostgreSQL. The interesting problem was keeping transfers consistent when multiple ones hit the same account at once — I handled that with transaction isolation and idempotency keys, and proved it with concurrent stress tests."

60 seconds

Add: what double-entry means and why consistency matters there, what specifically could go wrong under concurrency, and one sentence on the result of the stress testing.

2 minutes

Add: the specific mechanism (isolation level, idempotency key design, retry logic), why you chose that mechanism over an alternative, and what you learned about testing concurrent systems.

5 minutes

Add: the broader system context (how this fits with the rest of LedgerCore), a second example (e.g., the AI-suggestion story, S2, as a related judgment call), and reflection on what you'd do differently with more time.

6. Tell me about a difficult technical problem

Lead with BLUF, not backstory: "The core problem was X, and the reason it was hard was Y." Then walk investigation → hypotheses → actions → result → learning. Use S1, S3, or S4.

7. Tell me about a failure

> **IMPORTANT:** This is the one question where inventing an answer does the most damage, because a fake failure sounds fake under any follow-up. Fill in S10 (Part 5) with something real before you walk into an interview. If you genuinely cannot think of one, that itself is worth reflecting on honestly (see Part 25) rather than papering over with a fabricated story.

Structure: ownership → action → recovery → learning → changed behavior. Do not let the answer resolve into "but it all worked out great" — a real failure has a real, sometimes still slightly uncomfortable, cost.

8. Tell me about a conflict / disagreement

Use S11 once filled in, or S2 (disagreeing with an AI-generated suggestion) if you're not yet ready with a real interpersonal conflict — but say so honestly if directly asked for a person-to-person conflict (see Part 15 for how to bridge that). State the other person's view as something a reasonable person could hold. Never make them look foolish or malicious.

9. Tell me about a time you received feedback

Structure: feedback → reflection → behavior change → result. The interviewer is not scoring how good the feedback made you feel; they're scoring whether you can point to something you actually did differently afterward. Use S12 once filled in.

10. What is your weakness?

A good weakness answer has five parts: a real, moderate development area; evidence you recognize it; what you're actively doing about it; evidence of some improvement; what you still want to get better at. Avoid fake weaknesses ('I work too hard', 'I'm a perfectionist') and avoid weaknesses that would actually worry an engineering interviewer (e.g., 'I don't test my code').

> [FILL IN — a real, moderate weakness from your own experience — e.g., something like 'I sometimes go deep on a technical rabbit hole before stepping back to check it's worth the time' only if that is genuinely true for you; otherwise identify your own]

Then fill in:
• Evidence you recognize it: [FILL IN: a specific moment you noticed this in yourself]
• What you're doing about it: [FILL IN]
• Evidence of improvement: [FILL IN]
• What you still want to improve: [FILL IN]

11. Where do you see yourself in five years?

Show ambition, learning, and increasing responsibility without pretending to know your exact title. A safe honest shape: "I want to keep going deeper on [FILL IN: e.g., backend systems and data correctness], take on more ownership over a system end-to-end, and get to a point where I'm the one other people come to for [FILL IN: a specific area]." Avoid over-specific claims like naming a job title or company you have no real basis for.

12. What are you looking for in your next role?

For an internship: learning, mentorship, exposure to real systems and real constraints, and working alongside engineers more experienced than you. It's fine to say this directly — companies hiring interns expect it. Pair it with one concrete thing you already bring (e.g., the concurrency/reliability work from LedgerCore) so it doesn't sound purely one-directional.

PART 8

Follow-Up Question Training

20 chains. An interviewer rarely stops at your first answer. Practice these chains out loud, against any story that fits, until answering link 5 feels as easy as answering link 1.

IMPORTANT: These chains are patterns, not scripts written for a specific story. Pick a story from Part 5 that fits the chain's theme, then answer each link using that story's real details.

Technical decision chain

Tell me about a technical problem you faced. → Why did you choose that approach? → What alternatives did you consider? → Why didn't you choose the alternative? → What went wrong, if anything, with the approach you did choose? → What did you learn? → What would you do differently now? → How did you know your solution actually worked?

Root-cause chain

Tell me about a bug you had to track down. → What was your first hypothesis? → What told you that hypothesis was wrong? → What did you check next? → How did you finally confirm the actual cause? → How did you verify the fix? → How would you prevent this class of bug in the future?

AI-judgment chain

How do you use AI when you code? → Tell me about a time an AI suggestion was wrong. → How did you know it was wrong? → What did you do instead? → How do you generally verify AI-generated code? → Where's the line between using AI as leverage and depending on it? → Has AI ever helped you learn something, versus just producing an answer?

Ownership chain

Tell me about a time you took ownership of a problem. → Was it technically your responsibility, or did you choose to take it on? → What would have happened if you hadn't? → Who else was affected? → How did you communicate what you were doing to others? → What did it cost you to take this on (time, tradeoff)?

Failure chain

Tell me about a time you failed. → How did you find out it had gone wrong? → What was the actual impact? → What did you do in the immediate aftermath? → How did the people around you react? → What did you change afterward? → Has anything similar happened since?

Conflict chain

Tell me about a disagreement you had. → What did the other person believe, in their own terms? → Did you consider you might be wrong? → How was it actually resolved? → How's your relationship with them now? → What would you do differently if it happened again?

Feedback / coachability chain

Tell me about feedback you received. → What was your first reaction, honestly? → What did you specifically change? → How do you know the change helped? → Has anyone given you similar feedback since? → How do you actively ask for feedback, rather than waiting for it?

Leadership chain

Tell me about a time you led something. → What made you step into that role? → What specifically did you do that another person on the team couldn't or didn't do? → Did anyone push back on your approach? → How did you handle someone who was struggling? → What would you do if someone ignored your guidance?

Pressure / deadline chain

Tell me about working under a tight deadline. → What was actually at stake if you missed it? → What did you cut or simplify? → How did you decide what to cut? → Did the quality of your work suffer? Be honest. → What would you do differently with the same deadline again?

Prioritization chain

Tell me about competing priorities. → What were the actual options? → What criteria did you use to choose? → What happened to the thing you didn't prioritize? → Did anyone disagree with your prioritization? → Would you make the same call again?

Tradeoff / architecture chain

Tell me about a design decision you made. → What was the simplest alternative you considered? → Why wasn't the simplest option good enough? → What did the choice cost you (complexity, time)? → How would this decision change at 10x the scale? → Who else weighed in, and what was your specific contribution to the final call?

Learning-under-deadline chain

Tell me about learning something new quickly. → What was your process for learning it? → What's a concept you got wrong at first? → How did you know you finally understood it? → How long did it actually take? → What would you do differently to learn faster next time?

Quality / correctness chain

Tell me about a time you caught a bug before it caused a real problem. → What made you look for it in the first place? → How did you confirm it was real, not a false alarm? → How did you fix it? → How did you make sure it couldn't recur?

Persuasion chain

Tell me about persuading someone. → What was their starting position? → What evidence or argument actually changed their mind? → What if they still hadn't agreed? → How do you know it was genuine agreement and not just them giving in?

Initiative chain

Tell me about a time you took initiative. → Whose job was this originally, if anyone's? → What made you decide to act without being asked? → Did anyone tell you not to? → What was the actual outcome? → Has that become something you now do regularly?

Ambiguity chain

Tell me about a time requirements were unclear. → What assumptions did you make to move forward? → How did you validate those assumptions? → What would you have done if you'd guessed wrong? → How do you generally decide when to ask versus when to just proceed?

Scale / impact chain

Tell me about the impact of something you built. → How do you know that's the actual impact, not an assumption? → What would you measure if you had more visibility into it? → What's the honest, unverified version of this claim if someone pushed on the number?

Mentoring chain

Tell me about helping someone else improve. → How did you know they needed help? → What specifically did you do? → How did you know it was actually helping, versus just being nice? → What did you learn about teaching from this?

Disagreeing-up chain

Tell me about a time you disagreed with someone more experienced than you. → How did you raise it? → Were you nervous to push back? How did you handle that? → What happened? → Would you push back the same way again?

Project-depth chain

Walk me through a project end to end. → What part did you personally build versus your team? → What was the hardest part technically? → What would you rebuild if you started over? → What don't you like about it, looking back honestly?

PART 9

Project-Specific Behavioral Questions

Questions an interviewer may ask specifically about the Aggregation API or LedgerCore, with the story to reach for. Only speak to what you actually did — use the [FILL IN] blanks in Part 5 to prepare specifics before relying on these in a real interview.

Financial Account Aggregation API

Question	Reach for
Tell me about a difficult decision you made.	S5 — Kafka/Redis architecture tradeoff
Tell me about a technical mistake.	S10 if it happened on this project, otherwise be honest that your clearest mistake example is from elsewhere
Tell me about a time you had to learn something quickly.	S9 — new tech for this project
Tell me about a time you had to debug something.	S4 — duplicate transaction debugging
Tell me about a time you had competing approaches.	S5 — Kafka vs. simpler alternative
Tell me about a time you used AI.	S2 (if it applies to this project) or a general answer per Part 10
Tell me about a time you disagreed with an AI suggestion.	S2 — note this happened on LedgerCore; say so accurately rather than relocating it to this project
Tell me about a time you had to balance complexity and simplicity.	S5
Tell me about a time something failed.	S3 — provider failure handling (design side) or S10 if a real failure occurred here
Tell me about a time you improved a system.	S3 or S4 — closing a resilience or correctness gap
Tell me about a time you had to explain a technical decision.	S5, told at the depth appropriate for the audience (Part 7, Q1 'why this approach')
Tell me about a time you had to work with uncertainty.	S5 or S9 — deciding architecture or learning a new tool without a clear playbook

LedgerCore

Focus areas: concurrency, debugging, failure, AI judgment, testing, ownership, technical reasoning, reliability.

Question	Reach for
Tell me about a concurrency problem you solved.	S1
Tell me about a time you had to debug a subtle issue.	S1 or S2
Tell me about a time something failed or almost failed.	S1 (the risk you found) or S10 if a real failure occurred here
Tell me about a time you disagreed with an AI-generated suggestion.	S2
Tell me about how you test your work.	S1 — concurrent stress testing
Tell me about a time you took ownership of correctness.	S1 or S2
Tell me about your technical reasoning process for a hard problem.	S1

Question	Reach for
Tell me about a time you had to validate that something actually worked, not just looked right.	S1 — validating under real concurrent load rather than code review alone

PART 10

Responsible AI Behavioral Questions

Modern engineering roles assume you use AI tools. The organizing principle for every answer in this section: **AI is leverage, not dependency** — you move faster with it, but you remain personally responsible for correctness, security, testing, and actually understanding the result.

How do you use AI when coding?

Describe your real, current usage honestly — e.g., speeding up boilerplate, exploring an approach, explaining an unfamiliar API — without overclaiming fluency you don't have.

What happens when AI gives you incorrect code?

Use S2. The short version: you noticed it would mask a symptom rather than fix a cause, and rejected it in favor of the actual root cause.

Tell me about a time you disagreed with an AI-generated solution.

S2, full version (Part 5).

How do you verify AI-generated code?

[FILL IN: your actual practice — e.g., reading it line by line before accepting, running it against tests, checking it against your understanding of the system's invariants]

What are the risks of relying on AI?

It can produce code that runs and looks plausible while being wrong about the system's actual constraints (as in S2) — especially dangerous in a system like a financial ledger where a masked error is worse than a visible one.

How do you prevent AI from becoming a dependency?

[FILL IN: your actual habits — e.g., trying to solve a problem yourself first, using AI to check your understanding rather than replace it, being able to explain any code you ship without the AI's help]

How do you know when AI's suggestion is wrong?

By checking it against your own understanding of what the system actually needs to do (S2) — not by how confident or fluent the suggestion sounds.

Would you use AI to solve an unfamiliar problem?

Yes, as a starting point for understanding, the same way you'd use documentation — but you'd still validate the result yourself (tie to S9, learning new tech).

How do you balance productivity and understanding?

[FILL IN: your honest answer — e.g., using AI for speed on parts you already understand well, and slowing down to learn manually on parts you don't, so the balance shifts as your own understanding grows]

HONESTY CHECK: Do not exaggerate how much of your work is AI-assisted, and do not claim more verification process than you actually follow. This is one of the easiest sections to get caught overstating in a live follow-up.

PART 11

Impact and Metrics

How to talk about impact honestly — including when you don't have a clean number.

My verified metrics

- Team Nova (FarmLink) won the Youth Arise hackathon — a verifiable, real outcome.
- Role held: Training Lead and Programmer, Robotics Club.
- Worked as part of a 3-person team within the KNUST CS Open Source Community.
- [FILL IN: any other concrete, checkable fact — a competition placement, a specific number of members trained, a specific number of teams coached]

Impact statements I need to verify before using them

The following would strengthen your technical stories, but only if the number is real. Go find or re-derive each one before an interview; if you can't, say so honestly rather than estimating out loud.

Area	What to verify before your interview
LedgerCore concurrency	Exact number of concurrent transfers/requests used in your stress tests, and the pass/fail outcome.
LedgerCore reliability	Any before/after data on the consistency issue you fixed (e.g., whether you could reproduce it before the fix and not after, across how many runs).
Aggregation API dedup	Number of duplicate records observed before the fix, if any were ever actually observed, versus after.
Aggregation API resilience	Recovery behavior/time under a simulated provider outage in your own testing.
Test coverage	Number of test cases you wrote across either project, if you tracked this.
FarmLink	Number of teams competed against, hackathon duration, team size, judging criteria.
Robotics Club	Number of members trained, over what timeframe, any measurable change in their ability.
KNUST CS community	Number of teams coached, and outcome of any specific external opportunity pursued.

How to discuss impact honestly when you don't have an exact number

You don't need a fabricated number — you need a precise, honest sentence. Use one of these patterns:

- "I don't have an exact number, but the concrete result was [specific, observable thing that happened]."
- "I didn't track that formally — what I can tell you concretely is [specific test / observation / before-after behavior]."
- "That's a fair question — I'd want to go verify the exact figure rather than guess."

IMPORTANT: Never invent a number under follow-up pressure. An interviewer who catches one fabricated metric will (reasonably) discount every other metric you gave them.

PART 12

What Interviewers May Actually Hear

A critical, not flattering, read of each core story: the strong signal, the weak signal, the red flag, what's missing, and where a follow-up is most likely to expose a gap.

S1 — LedgerCore concurrency

Strong: real systems-level correctness reasoning for a junior candidate.

Weak: if you can't state a concrete test result, it sounds like design without proof.

Red flag: none, if you're honest about what you actually verified.

Missing: the real outcome number/behavior of the stress test.

Vulnerable to: 'how do you know it actually worked' — have a real answer, not a hand-wave.

S2 — Rejecting an AI suggestion

Strong: rare, valuable signal of independent technical judgment.

Weak: if you can't say specifically what the AI suggested, it sounds generic/invented.

Red flag: overclaiming this happens 'all the time' when it may be a single instance.

Missing: the specific suggestion and the specific real root cause.

Vulnerable to: 'what exactly did it suggest' — this is the first thing to fill in.

S3/S4/S5 — Aggregation API

Strong: realistic system design thinking (failure isolation, dedup, architecture tradeoffs).

Weak: 'mock bank providers' means this wasn't tested against real-world chaos — be ready to say so if asked.

Red flag: implying this was a production system with real users, when it's a project with simulated providers.

Missing: concrete test results for the failure/dedup scenarios.

Vulnerable to: 'did real users ever hit this' — answer honestly that providers were mocked.

S6 — FarmLink hackathon

Strong: a genuine competitive result (a win) is rare, credible evidence.

Weak: currently almost entirely unfilled — without your specific role, it reads as 'my team won' rather than 'here's what I contributed to the win'.

Red flag: claiming outsized personal credit for a team win without specifics to back it up.

Missing: your specific actions, and the team's process under time pressure.

Vulnerable to: 'what did you personally build or decide' — fill this in before relying on it.

S7 — Robotics Club Training Lead

Strong: a leadership title with real teaching responsibility is good raw material.

Weak: currently a title with no described action.

Red flag: describing the title without ever naming something you actually did or someone you actually helped.

Missing: a specific member, a specific method, a specific result.

Vulnerable to: 'tell me about one specific person you helped' — this is the likeliest follow-up and the card is currently blank there.

S8 — KNUST CS community pitch coaching

Strong: coaching other teams shows persuasion and communication beyond your own project.

Weak: currently generic — 'helped teams refine ideas' is a description, not a story.

Red flag: taking credit for another team's idea or outcome.

Missing: one specific team, one specific piece of feedback, one specific outcome.

Vulnerable to: 'what changed about their pitch because of you, specifically' — fill this in.

S9 — Learning fast

Strong: pairs well with S5 as proof the architecture decision was actually understood, not copied.

Weak: 'I learned it from docs' alone is thin.

Red flag: none inherent.

Missing: which technology specifically, and a concept that was genuinely hard at first.

Vulnerable to: 'explain how it actually works' — make sure your technical depth here is real, not surface-level.

PART 13

Common Behavioral Mistakes and How to Fix Them

Mistake	What it looks like	The fix
Talking too much	Answer runs past ~2 minutes with no signal the interviewer wants more.	Lead with BLUF, then stop after Situation/Task/Action/Result and let them ask for more.
Giving excessive context	5 sentences of backstory before the actual point.	Cut context to only what's needed to understand the decision that follows.
Using 'we' instead of 'I'	Interviewer can't tell what you personally did.	Explicitly say 'I decided / I built / I noticed' for your part, 'we' only for genuinely shared actions.
Memorizing scripts	Answer sounds identical word-for-word every time you tell it.	Practice from the bullet points in Part 5, never from a written paragraph.
Sounding rehearsed	Flat delivery, no natural pauses, transitions feel canned.	Practice out loud in different orders; use Part 14's natural transition phrases sparingly.
Giving generic answers	Answer would be equally true for any candidate.	Anchor every claim to a specific project detail only you would know.
Not answering the actual question	Answer is technically related but dodges what was asked.	Restate the question in your own head before answering; if unsure, ask a clarifying question (Part 14).
Blaming teammates	A conflict or failure story makes someone else look bad.	State the other person's position fairly; own your own part regardless of theirs.
Making failures sound fake	The 'failure' is actually a strength ('I care too much').	Use a real mistake with a real, sometimes uncomfortable, cost (Part 5, S10).
Avoiding responsibility	Passive voice hides who was responsible.	Use active 'I' language even when the fact is unflattering.
Claiming impossible results	A number or outcome that couldn't plausibly be true for the scope of the project.	Scale claims to the actual size of a student/hackathon project.
Inventing metrics	A precise-sounding number with no real source.	Use Part 11's honest patterns instead: state what you actually know.
Giving no measurable result	Story ends at 'and then it worked' with nothing concrete.	Add at least one observable outcome, even if it's qualitative ('sync continued for other accounts during the simulated outage').
Saying 'I don't know' without demonstrating learning	A knowledge gap with no follow-through.	Pair 'I don't know' with what you'd do to find out, or what you learned since.
Turning every answer into a technical explanation	Human-focused questions (failure, conflict) get answered with architecture diagrams.	Match structure to question type (Part 2's business-vs-human distinction) — lead with the human reasoning first.
Turning every answer into a leadership story	Forcing 'Training Lead' into unrelated questions.	Use the coverage matrix (Part 4) to pick the story that actually fits, not the one that sounds most impressive.
Speaking negatively about teammates	Frustration leaks into tone or word choice.	Describe behavior and disagreement, not character judgments.
Speaking negatively about previous organizations	Applies less for a student, but avoid trashing a club, course, or team experience.	Frame any friction as something you learned from, not something that was 'badly run'.
Not knowing the company	Generic 'why this company' answer.	Use Part 17's research framework before every interview, not just the big-name ones.

Mistake	What it looks like	The fix
Not asking meaningful questions	Silence or a question already answered in the job posting at the end of the interview.	Prepare from Part 18's bank and tailor at least one question to something the interviewer said earlier in the conversation.

PART 14

Conversational Delivery

Sounding like a person talking, not a page being read aloud.

Habits to build

- Pause for a second before answering — a brief pause reads as thoughtful, not unprepared.
- If a question is ambiguous, ask a clarifying question rather than guessing what they meant.
- It's fine to think out loud briefly ("let me think of the clearest example...") — it sounds human, as long as you don't do it for 30 seconds.
- Keep an internal structure (Situation/Task/Action/Result) without narrating the labels out loud.
- Maintain camera/eye engagement; notice if the interviewer looks like they want to jump in.
- Cut filler words ('um', 'like', 'basically') by slowing down slightly, not by rushing.
- Adjust length based on their reaction — leaning in and taking notes means go deeper; a nod and a beat of silence means wrap up.
- Recognize when you've answered enough: if you've hit BLUF + Situation + Task + Action + Result, stop and let them drive.

Useful transitions (use sparingly, not as a checklist)

- "The biggest challenge was..."
- "That was the main constraint I was working around."
- "The decision came down to two real options."
- "What I personally did was..."
- "The important lesson for me was..."
- "Looking back, I'd probably..."
- "To be specific about my part in this..."

IMPORTANT: If you use the same transition phrase in every single answer, it starts to sound as scripted as a memorized paragraph. Rotate naturally.

PART 15

Handling Questions You Don't Have a Perfect Story For

You have not had a manager, a paid job, or (as far as your background material shows) a serious interpersonal conflict on a team. That's normal for someone at this stage — and inventing one to avoid saying so is far riskier than answering honestly and pivoting to a real, adjacent example.

The bridge pattern

"I haven't had that exact situation yet, but I've experienced something similar when [FILL IN: real adjacent example] — here's what happened." Then tell the real story fully. Don't apologize repeatedly or dwell on the gap; one sentence, then move to substance.

Common substitutions for a student/early-career candidate

If asked about...	Bridge to...
A disagreement with your manager	A disagreement with a hackathon teammate, club co-lead, or an AI-generated suggestion (S2, S11).
Managing a direct report	Training/mentoring newer Robotics Club members (S7).
A production incident	The concurrency risk you found and fixed in LedgerCore before it became a real incident (S1), or provider-failure handling in the Aggregation API (S3).
A performance review	Specific feedback from a teammate, club lead, or code review (S12).
Negotiating with a client	Persuading a team to adopt your idea for their pitch (S8).
Working across departments/teams	Coordinating with teammates under hackathon time pressure (S6), or working across the KNUST CS community with different teams (S8).

IMPORTANT: Never invent a manager, a job, or a workplace conflict you didn't have. Interviewers interviewing students expect exactly the substitutions above, and respect the honesty of the bridge far more than a fabricated corporate anecdote.

PART 16

Hypothetical Behavioral Questions

Answer the hypothetical briefly, then ground it in a real example.

How would you handle a disagreement?

General approach: listen fully, look at the evidence, state your view clearly, be willing to update. "I actually faced something like this when..." → S2 or S11.

How do you prioritize tasks?

General approach: identify what's actually blocking or highest-stakes, confirm with whoever set the priorities if unclear. "For example..." → S6 or S9.

What would you do if you were behind schedule?

General approach: reassess scope honestly, communicate early rather than late, cut the least critical piece first. "This happened during ..." → S6.

What would you do if a teammate was struggling?

General approach: figure out specifically where they're stuck before jumping to a fix, offer to pair rather than just telling them the answer. "I did something similar when..." → S7.

What would you do if your manager asked you to do something you disagreed with?

General approach: raise the concern once clearly with reasoning, then follow the decision unless it's an integrity issue. Bridge honestly: "I haven't had a manager yet, but a similar case was..." → S2 or S11.

What would you do if you discovered a serious bug before release?

General approach: flag it immediately regardless of how it affects the timeline, don't quietly patch around it. "This is close to what happened when..." → S2 or S4.

PART 17

Company-Specific Preparation Framework

A reusable checklist. Do this research fresh for every company — JPMorgan Chase, Goldman Sachs, Bloomberg, Bank of America, Google, or anyone else — rather than reusing generic talking points.

IMPORTANT: This document does not fabricate company-specific facts for you. Every cell below is a prompt to go verify, not a pre-filled answer — company details change, and a stale or invented fact is worse than admitting you'd need to check.

Category	What to research	Type
Company	What does it actually do? Who are its real customers?	Fact (verify)
Technology	What engineering problems does it solve? What systems/technologies does it discuss publicly (engineering blog, conference talks)?	Fact (verify)
Role	What does the specific role involve, per the posting and, ideally, per the recruiter/interviewer? What skills does it emphasize?	Fact (verify)
Culture / values	What does the company explicitly say it values (careers page, engineering blog, public statements)?	Fact (verify)
My connection	Why do those specific, verified facts genuinely interest you — tied to a real project or interest of yours, not a generic compliment.	Your interpretation

Worked skeleton (fill in real research before use)

> "[Company fact you verified] stood out to me because I've been working on [FILL IN: related project detail, e.g., failure isolation in the Aggregation API]. I want to see how that kind of problem is handled at [FILL IN: their scale/domain], and [FILL IN: specific role detail] is where I'd actually get to do that."

IMPORTANT: Never say a company is 'innovative' or 'prestigious' as the substance of your answer — those words carry zero information about why you specifically want to be there.

PART 18

Questions to Ask the Interviewer

Avoid anything answered by the job posting. Prefer questions you can follow up on based on what they actually say.

Engineering

- What does the on-call or incident-response process look like for this team?
- How does the team decide between building something in-house versus using an existing tool?
- What's a recent technical decision the team debated, and how was it resolved?

Team

- How is the team structured, and how does this role fit into it?
- How do engineers on this team typically split time between new features and maintenance?

Mentorship

- What does mentorship look like for someone in this role — formal, informal, assigned?
- What's something a past intern or new hire struggled with, and how did the team support them?

Learning

- What's something you've personally learned in this role that surprised you?
- What resources or practices does the team use to ramp people up on unfamiliar systems?

Role

- What would success look like in the first three months in this role?
- What's the balance between independent work and pairing/collaboration day to day?

Projects

- What's a project the team shipped recently that you're proud of?
- What's the most technically interesting problem the team is currently working on?

Career development

- What does growth from this role typically look like a year or two in?
- How does the team give feedback — formal reviews, ongoing, both?

Company

- How has the team's priorities shifted in the last year, and why?
- What's something about working here that isn't obvious from the outside?

Following up naturally

If the interviewer's answer to one of these mentions something specific (a tool, a project, a challenge), ask one genuine follow-up about that specific thing rather than moving straight to your next prepared question — it's the clearest signal you

were actually listening.

PART 19

Mock Interview System

Six practice modes. Run these out loud — alone, recorded, or with a friend — not silently in your head.

Mode 1 — Rapid behavioral (10 questions, short answers)

Goal: clarity and conciseness. Give yourself 60–90 seconds per answer, no follow-ups. Pull 10 questions at random from Part 24.

Mode 2 — Deep behavioral (5 questions, heavy follow-ups)

Goal: depth and consistency under pressure. Pick 5 questions from Part 6. After each answer, immediately fire 3–4 follow-ups from the matching chain in Part 8.

Mode 3 — Project-focused

Goal: technical-behavioral fluency. Use only Part 9's Aggregation API and LedgerCore questions. Answer at 60 seconds first, then again at 2 minutes for the same question.

Mode 4 — Company motivation

Run this exact sequence: Tell me about yourself → Why this company? → Why this role? → Where do you see yourself in five years? → your prepared questions from Part 18. Do this once per company you're actually interviewing with, using real research (Part 17).

Mode 5 — Pressure test

Goal: handling the unexpected. Have someone else (or a randomizer) pick questions from Part 24 without telling you in advance, including at least one you don't have a clean story for — practice the bridge pattern from Part 15 live.

Mode 6 — Follow-up interrogation

Goal: defending one story under real pressure. Pick a single story from Part 5. Have a partner ask follow-up after follow-up — not from a fixed list — until you either run out of real detail or five minutes pass. Where you ran out of real detail is exactly where you need to fill in more from your own memory before a real interview.

PART 20

Scoring Rubric

Score each practice answer on these dimensions as Strong / Developing / Needs work. This is diagnostic, not a hire/no-hire score.

Dimension	Ask yourself
Relevance	Did I actually answer the question asked, not an adjacent one?
Structure	Was the answer easy to follow — BLUF, then Situation/Task/Action/Result?
Ownership	Was my personal contribution clearly distinguished from the team's?
Communication	Was I clear, at the right level of detail for the listener?
Conciseness	Did I avoid unnecessary context or rambling?
Evidence	Did I give a concrete example rather than a general claim?
Impact	Did I explain what actually resulted, honestly?
Self-awareness	Did I recognize my own mistakes or limitations where relevant?
Learning	Did I explain what changed afterward, not just what happened?
Coachability	Did I show an actual behavior change, not just openness in the abstract?
Authenticity	Did I sound like I was talking, not reciting?
Follow-up readiness	Could I defend every detail if pushed on it?

IMPORTANT: If two or more dimensions come back 'Needs work' on the same story repeatedly, that's a signal to revise the story card in Part 5, not to keep re-practicing the same weak version.

PART 21

30 / 60 / 2-Minute Answer Compression

The same story, expanding outward from the same core point. Nothing here is a separate script — each longer version is literally the shorter version plus more of the real detail.

S2 — Rejecting an AI suggestion

30 seconds

"While working on LedgerCore, an AI tool suggested a fix that would've made an error disappear without actually fixing what caused it. I rejected it and traced the real cause instead."

60 seconds

Add: what specifically the AI suggested, why it would have masked rather than solved the problem, and what the actual root cause turned out to be.

2 minutes

Add: how you verified the real fix, what this taught you about reviewing AI output in a system where correctness really matters, and how this shapes how you use AI tools generally now.

S6 — FarmLink hackathon

30 seconds

"As part of Team Nova, I [FILL IN: your specific contribution] on FarmLink during the Youth Arise hackathon, and our team won."

60 seconds

Add: the specific problem FarmLink solved, your specific role versus your teammates', and the biggest constraint you worked around under the time limit.

2 minutes

Add: a specific decision you personally pushed for, how the team coordinated under pressure, and what you learned about scoping ambition to time available.

IMPORTANT: Watch the interviewer, not the clock: someone leaning in after your 30-second version wants the 60- or 2-minute version next, unprompted. Someone who moves on wants you to stay short.

PART 22

Active Recall Exercises

Close the document. Answer these from memory. Then check yourself against the earlier parts — don't peek first.

Round 1 — Story inventory

- What are your 12 story slots, by ID and one-line title?
- Which 3 are still templates you need to fill in?
- For each of your 9 concrete stories, what competency is its strongest fit?

Round 2 — Per-story recall (pick any 3 stories and answer all 5)

- What happened, in one sentence (the BLUF)?
- What did I personally do, distinct from anyone else involved?
- What was the actual result?
- What did I learn?
- What would I do differently?

Round 3 — Defense

- For S1: what metric can I actually defend if asked 'how do you know it worked'?
- For S2: what exactly did the AI suggest, and what was the real root cause?
- For S5: what was the simpler alternative, and why wasn't it enough?
- For whichever gap story (S10/S11/S12) I've filled in: what's the one follow-up most likely to expose a thin spot, and do I have a real answer for it?

IMPORTANT: If you can't answer Round 3 from memory, that story isn't ready for a real interview yet — go back to Part 5 and add the missing detail honestly, don't just reread this section.

PART 23

Story Retrieval Drills

The goal is speed: given a competency, you should be able to name a story within 2–3 seconds, not after searching.

Go down this list without looking at Part 4. For each competency, say out loud which story you'd use and why, in under 10 seconds. Then check yourself against the coverage matrix.

- Competency: Leadership
- Competency: Failure
- Competency: Conflict
- Competency: Technical communication
- Competency: Coachability
- Competency: Initiative
- Competency: Prioritization
- Competency: Adaptability
- Competency: Ownership
- Competency: Persuasion
- Competency: Decision-making
- Competency: Curiosity
- Competency: Working under pressure
- Competency: Attention to quality
- Competency: Responsible use of AI

PART 24

Random Question Bank

A large, deliberately unsorted mix for practice — easy, unusual, hypothetical, project-specific, and human-focused questions all together. The point is to test whether you actually understand your experience, not whether you've memorized which bucket a question belongs to.

- What's a project you're proud of, and why?
- Tell me about a time you had to say no to something.
- How do you approach code review, either giving or receiving it?
- Tell me about a time your first solution to a problem was wrong.
- What's the most complex system you've worked on?
- Tell me about a time you had to work with incomplete information.
- How do you handle being told your approach is wrong?
- Tell me about a time you had to choose between speed and correctness.
- What's something you built that nobody asked you to build?
- Tell me about a time you had to give someone unwelcome feedback.
- How do you decide when a bug is worth fixing right now versus later?
- Tell me about a time you were the least experienced person in the room.
- What would your teammates say your biggest strength is?
- Tell me about a time you had to trust someone else's work without verifying it yourself.
- How do you approach learning a codebase you didn't write?
- Tell me about a time a tool or library let you down.
- What's a technical opinion you hold that not everyone agrees with?
- Tell me about a time you had to make a tradeoff between two things you both cared about.
- How do you know when you're done with a task, versus just tired of it?
- Tell me about a time you asked for help.
- What's the difference between a good and a great engineer, in your view?
- Tell me about a time you had to unlearn something you thought was true.
- How would you explain what an API is to your grandparent?
- Tell me about a time you were wrong about how long something would take.
- What's a mistake you see other people make that you try to avoid?
- Tell me about a time you had to defend a decision to a skeptical audience.
- How do you stay organized across multiple things happening at once?
- Tell me about a time you changed your mind about a technical approach mid-project.
- What does 'ownership' mean to you, concretely?
- Tell me about a time you had to work with a tool you didn't like.
- How do you handle a task with no clear owner?
- Tell me about a time you caught your own mistake before anyone else did.
- What's a skill you're actively trying to improve right now?
- Tell me about a time you had to simplify something that was overly complex.
- How do you decide how much testing is enough?
- Tell me about a time you worked with someone very different from you.

- What's the hardest technical concept you've had to learn?
- Tell me about a time a plan changed at the last minute.
- How do you handle criticism of something you built?
- Tell me about a time you had to be patient with a slower process than you wanted.
- What's something you'd do differently if you restarted LedgerCore from scratch?
- Tell me about a time you helped debug something that wasn't your code.
- How do you balance perfectionism with shipping something on time?
- Tell me about a time you misjudged how difficult something would be.
- What's a question you wish interviewers would ask you?
- Tell me about a time you had to advocate for doing something the 'right' way under time pressure.
- How do you approach a problem you've truly never seen before?
- Tell me about a time you worked without much supervision.
- What's a risk you took that didn't pay off?
- Tell me about a time you had to communicate bad news.
- How would a teammate describe working with you under pressure?
- Tell me about a time you improved a process, not just a piece of code.
- What's something about the Aggregation API you'd want to redesign with more time?
- Tell me about a time you had to make a call without your team lead available.
- How do you handle a disagreement about priorities with someone senior to you?
- Tell me about a time you were the one who found a problem nobody else had noticed.
- What does a 'good day of work' look like for you?
- Tell me about a time you had to say 'I don't know' in front of others.
- How do you decide what to automate versus do manually?
- Tell me about a time you had to rebuild trust after something went wrong.
- What's the last thing you taught yourself, outside of a class requirement?

PART 25

Your Personal Behavioral Gaps

An honest read of where your evidence is strong, moderate, or weak — and how to close the real gaps through more real experience, not through better storytelling.

Competency	Evidence strength	Why
Technical problem solving	Strong	S1, S3, S4 are all real, specific, and defensible.
Technical decision-making / tradeoffs	Strong	S5 is a genuine architecture tradeoff with real reasoning.
Responsible AI use	Strong	S2 is a specific, credible, non-generic story — rare among candidates.
Attention to quality / correctness	Strong	S1, S2, S4 all show real diligence about correctness.
Leadership	Moderate	S7 (Robotics) and S6 (FarmLink) are real roles, but currently need specific actions and results filled in to be strong evidence rather than titles.
Teamwork / collaboration	Moderate	S6 and S8 are real, but thin on specifics of what you personally contributed versus the group.
Persuasion / communication with non-engineers	Moderate	S8 is a good foundation but needs one specific, filled-in example to be strong.
Learning agility / curiosity	Moderate	S9 is plausible given the projects, but needs a specific technology and moment filled in.
Failure and learning	Weak (currently a gap)	No specific, real failure was included in your background material. This is the single most important gap to close before interviews, since 'tell me about a failure' is one of the most common behavioral questions.
Interpersonal conflict resolution	Weak (currently a gap)	S2 covers disagreeing with an AI suggestion, but not a person-to-person conflict. Likely to come up directly.
Receiving and acting on feedback	Weak (currently a gap)	No specific feedback-and-change story was in your background material. Very likely to come up given how strongly interviewers weight coachability for junior candidates.
Customer / user focus	Weak-to-moderate	Your projects use mock providers, not real users — be honest about this rather than implying real customer impact you didn't have.

How to close these gaps for real, not just for the interview

- **Failure and learning:** Reflect honestly on LedgerCore or the Aggregation API — was there a version of your dedup or concurrency fix that didn't work the first time? A design choice you reversed? That is real material for S10, if you look for it honestly instead of assuming you need a dramatic failure.
- **Conflict resolution:** Look at FarmLink and the KNUST CS community work again — a hackathon under time pressure and a 3-person team almost always produce at least one real disagreement about approach or scope. Recall it honestly rather than assuming there wasn't one.
- **Feedback and coachability:** Think about code review comments (human or AI), a Robotics Club member's reaction to your teaching, or a KNUST CS teammate's reaction to your pitch feedback — feedback doesn't require a formal review process to count.
- **Customer/user focus:** Consider contributing to an actual open-source project with real users, or extending a personal project so it has real (even if small) usage, if you want genuine evidence here rather than just an honest disclosure of the gap.

- **Leadership and teamwork specifics:** These aren't gaps in experience, just gaps in documentation — go fill in S6, S7, and S8 with real detail; the experience is already there.

IMPORTANT: Do not fabricate a failure, a conflict, or feedback to fill these gaps. If, after honest reflection, a gap is genuinely empty, say so plainly if asked directly, and use the bridge pattern from Part 15. A thoughtfully honest 'I haven't had that yet' is stronger evidence of self-awareness than a fabricated story that collapses under a follow-up.

PART 26

Your Personal Behavioral Handbook

The one section to reread the night before an interview. Everything else in this document feeds into this page.

My core stories (fill in once S6–S12 are complete)

- S1 — LedgerCore concurrency and idempotency
- S2 — Rejecting an AI suggestion on LedgerCore
- S3 — Aggregation API provider failure handling
- S4 — Aggregation API duplicate prevention
- S5 — Kafka/Redis architecture tradeoff
- S6 — FarmLink hackathon (Team Nova, won)
- S7 — Robotics Club Training Lead
- S8 — KNUST CS Open Source Community pitch coaching
- S9 — Learning new technology fast
- S10, S11, S12 — [FILL IN once completed]

My main strengths (per Part 25)

- Technical problem solving under real constraints (concurrency, failure handling, duplicates).
- Independent technical judgment, including toward AI-generated suggestions.
- Attention to correctness in systems where correctness actually matters (financial data).

My development areas (per Part 25)

- Documenting leadership and teamwork stories with specific actions, not just roles.
- Building and being honest about a real failure story.
- Building and being honest about a real interpersonal-conflict story.
- Building and being honest about a real feedback-and-change story.

My career direction

[FILL IN — one or two honest sentences on where you want to grow — e.g., toward backend systems, data correctness, distributed systems — based on what actually drew you into LedgerCore and the Aggregation API]

Why software engineering / why backend systems / why internships

[FILL IN — your honest, short answer, built from Part 7 sections 1–2 and 12]

My strongest story, by category

Category	Your story
Strongest technical project	LedgerCore (S1) or the Aggregation API (S3/S4/S5)

Category	Your story
Strongest teamwork story	S6 (FarmLink) once filled in, or S8
Strongest failure/learning story	S10 — must be filled in with a real incident first
Strongest leadership story	S7 (Robotics Club) once filled in with specifics
Strongest technical challenge	S1 — concurrency and idempotency
Strongest AI/engineering judgment story	S2
Strongest communication story	S8 or S5, depending on the audience in the question

My key metrics (per Part 11)

- Team Nova (FarmLink) won the Youth Arise hackathon.
- Robotics Club: Training Lead and Programmer.
- KNUST CS Open Source Community: part of a 3-person team.
- [FILL IN any additional verified metric from Part 11]

Questions I can ask interviewers (see Part 18 for the full bank)

- One from Engineering.
- One from Mentorship or Career development.
- One built live from something the interviewer said earlier in the conversation.

PART Final

Final Interview Checklist

Story preparation

[ ] I know my 8–12 core stories.

[ ] I know what happened in each story.

[ ] I know what I personally did.

[ ] I know the result.

[ ] I know what I learned.

[ ] I know what I would do differently.

[ ] I know the competencies each story demonstrates.

[ ] I have filled in every [FILL IN] blank in S6–S12 with real, honest detail.

Delivery

[ ] I can answer without memorizing a script.

[ ] I can give a 30-second version.

[ ] I can give a 60-second version.

[ ] I can expand when asked.

[ ] I can stay concise when a short answer is enough.

[ ] I can use 'I' when describing my contribution.

[ ] I can explain technical concepts simply, for a non-technical listener.

Behavioral competencies

[ ] Teamwork

[ ] Communication

[ ] Leadership

[ ] Ownership

[ ] Failure

[ ] Learning

[ ] Coachability

[ ] Conflict

[ ] Prioritization

[ ] Adaptability

[ ] Initiative

[ ] Problem solving

[ ] Decision-making

[ ] Technical communication

[ ] Responsible use of AI

Company preparation

[ ] I know what the company does.

[ ] I understand the role.

[ ] I know why I genuinely want the role.

[ ] I can explain the connection between my goals and the role.

[ ] I have thoughtful questions prepared.

Follow-ups

[ ] I can explain why I made decisions.

[ ] I can explain alternatives I considered.

[ ] I can explain tradeoffs.

[ ] I can admit what I do not know.

[ ] I can explain mistakes honestly.

[ ] I can explain what I learned.

[ ] I can defend my stories without inventing details.

The final principle. Do not memorize answers. Know your experiences. Know what you did. Know why you did it. Know what happened. Know what you learned. Know what you would change. Know what tradeoffs existed. Know how your behavior changed afterward. Then adapt those stories naturally to whatever the interviewer actually asks. By the end of the conversation, the interviewer should understand who you are, how you work, how you learn, how you solve problems, how you work with people, how you respond when things go wrong, and why you want the role.